

An herbal supplement containing Ma Huang-Guarana for weight loss: a randomized, double-blind trial.

OBJECTIVE: To examine in overweight humans the short-term safety and efficacy for weight loss of an herbal supplement containing Ma Huang, Guarana and other ingredients. **DESIGN:** An 8 week randomized, double-blind placebo controlled study of a herbal dietary supplement (72 mg/day ephedrine alkaloids and 240 mg/day caffeine). **SUBJECTS:** Overweight men and women (body mass index, ≥ 29 and ≤ 35 kg/m²). **MEASUREMENTS:** The primary outcome variable was body weight change. Secondary variables included anthropometric, metabolic and cardiovascular changes. **RESULTS:** Sixty-seven subjects were randomized to either placebo (n=32) or active Ma Huang/Guarana (n=35). Twenty-four subjects in each group completed the study. Active treatment produced significantly ($P<0.006$) greater loss of weight ($X\pm s.d.$, -4.0 ± 3.4 kg) and fat ($-2.1\pm 3.0\%$ fat) over the 8-week treatment period than did placebo (-0.8 ± 2.4 kg and $0.2\pm 2.3\%$ fat). Active treatment also produced greater reductions in hip circumference and serum triglyceride levels. Eight of the 35 actively treated subjects (23%) and none of the 32 placebo-treated control subjects withdrew from the protocol because of potential treatment-related effects. Dry mouth, insomnia and headache were the adverse symptoms reported most frequently by the herbal vs placebo group at the final evaluation visit. **CONCLUSIONS:** This herbal mixture of Ma Huang and Guarana effectively promoted short-term weight and fat loss. Safety with long-term use requires further investigation.